

An Angel Told Me I Was Going To Heaven

Traditional caged eggs come from chickens who are raised their whole lives in a small metal box. They never see the sun, they never leave their cage, they barely have any space to move around; They stare at the same wall for the entirety of their existence. Naturally, caged eggs are the cheapest. Cage free eggs are one step higher in terms of price. These chickens are raised in big silos, packed wing to wing. They opened up all the cages but left the doors closed. Free range eggs are the third tier up. These chickens get two square feet of outdoor space, about the size of two pieces of paper. They aren't always guaranteed this space, but unlike their caged and cage-free brethren, they can see the sun. Pasture raised chickens get 108 square feet of space, about the size of half a garage, or a small room. Pasture raised eggs are the most expensive of the four. I've always been most curious about the free range chickens however. For that extra dollar, the chickens get to feel the sunlight, they are allowed knowledge of its existence. Do they appreciate that? Do they appreciate those two pieces of paper they're given? Being able to experience the sun and nothing else.

The fridge light clicked on as I pulled open the door, hand lazily examining the contents. I pulled out a cardboard container of eggs, and an old package of bacon. My kitchen was far too small to ever cook anything of real substance. This apartment was clearly not designed to house a human. I flicked on the burner, placing two strips of bacon in the pan. I had no toaster, so I usually just heated my bread up in the oven, it never got that toasted though, it mostly just got hard. I cracked in the last two eggs from the cart, tossing the empty container into the grocery bag beside my trash. My eyes wandered over to the window at the end of my short hallway of a kitchen. It faced a wall, but there was just enough space that if I craned my neck, I could see the street outside my apartment building.

My mind was ripped from its wanton wandering by the sound like crackling thunder. I jumped and turned as the window disappeared from view, obscured by a cloud of thick white smoke. My body tumbled backwards and I crawled towards my bedroom door, rounding the kitchen corner when a figure stepped out from the smoke. He was young and tanned, short black hair and brown eyes, his body covered in a white prayer shawl. He appeared tall, seven or eight feet, so much so the top of his head nearly brushed the ceiling. His form emitted a light as if backlit, dimming his silhouette, but not enough to obscure his visage. I opened my mouth to speak but all that came out was a distressed confusion.

"Quiet child," the figure said with its right hand raised, "I am not here to harm you. I am Malak, your guardian angel. I am here to give you good news." I lay against the floor, back touching the wall. My heart thundered within my chest, enough that I could see my body shake with every beat. The man smiled at me kindly, and I glanced behind him towards the eggs and bacon still cooking on the stove. "I am here to inform you that the rapture is occurring, and you are one of the few who will be brought back into the kingdom of heaven." My focus returned to the angel before me.

“W-why me? I’m not even religious,” I sputtered, my words coming out slow. Malak smiled wider.

“Your thoughts were fine and your actions were good. You didn’t believe in Jesus but you followed him nonetheless, even if you would say otherwise.” My eyes returned to the pan on the stove; I could smell the bacon beginning to burn.

“So, what does that mean for me? What happens in heaven? Is it really in the clouds? Does it look like it does in the Simpsons?” I was standing now.

“You will love it. You will stand beside all the children of God and sing. You will be witness to God for all eternity, singing his praise and glory, not needing for food or water or rest. You will experience pure bliss, true ecstasy; you will not want, you will not need, all you will desire to do is witness God’s glory and sing with his creations in joy. You will love it.” I thought about it for a moment, about spending all eternity in God’s presence, wanting and needing for nothing else.

“Can I never eat again? I know I won’t need to eat but, can I just, not eat ever again?” I asked.

“You will have no desire to, child, you will be fully satiated, wanting not for any earthly materials.” I began to dislike his use of the term ‘child.’

“But, what if I want to eat now? I like the taste of bacon and eggs.” My eyes shifted again to the pan, the bacon was definitely burnt, it’ll start to smoke if I don’t turn it off soon. “I know I won’t want to do those things when I’m in heaven, but I don’t want to not want to do those things.”

“Child, that is because this is all you know. Once you see the image of God, all desires will leave you, you will only want to praise his glory.”

“But, I don’t want that. Eternity is a really long time, like, longer than I can fathom. Are you really telling me I’ll never get bored? I’ll never want to do anything else? I-I want to write a novel, I’ll never get to write my novel if I go to heaven. I’ll never get to In-N-Out. I don’t know if it’ll be any good but I want to at least know what it tastes like.”

“Any experience you may have on this Earth will pale in comparison to what you will experience in heaven above. It will be so great that you will forget every other experience, every other memory. This will be all you know, and all you ever need to know.” My breath was picking up, and his calm demeanor did nothing to abate my growing panic. His smile was unfaltering, he had barely moved since he appeared, his posture relaxed but hyper-present. He didn’t seem malicious or even annoyed at my questions, he didn’t seem to judge this situation with the weight I felt appropriate. I found myself wishing there was some malintent in his tone, it would at least feel more fitting for my present moment.

“I’ll just forget all my memories of life? Why can’t I keep those? Why do those have to be taken away as well?”

“They won’t be taken away, they will simply fall aside as you experience true beauty and perfection. Your mind will willingly forget all else. Every wrong you have experienced, every

bad thought, every trauma, every negative emotion, they will all disappear.” The bread in the oven was probably burnt now too.

“I don’t want to forget them. If I lose all my bad memories, I won’t be able to see how far I’ve come, I won’t have anything to compare with my good emotions.” My words were babbling now. “How will I be able to appreciate anything if I don’t know what it is to not have it?”

“God’s presence will simply be that great. You won’t need anything to compare it to, you will simply know it to be perfect, and you will be happy.”

“Can my consciousness just end? I don’t want to go to Hell but, can I just stop experiencing things entirely? Can I just die and not go anywhere, is that possible?”

“Your place has already been determined child, you will be in heaven with God soon, it will be wonderful. You will be in paradise.” The pan was smoking a little, but not as much as I would have thought, it was mainly the smell that got me. The burnt bread was really more present than anything else.

Our conversation was overtaken by that same rumbling which announced his presence. I turned to the window, watching as red light flushed in, the glass shattering inwards. It felt like I was hit with a torrent of wind, my feet leaving the floor for a moment, and the red light turned to white.

I opened my eyes to find myself in an endless horizon. The ground was white, and the air had the lightest layer of fog. There were millions of people. I didn’t count that many, but I assumed there had to be if I was let in. I was fully undressed, as was everyone else, though I didn’t feel cold; I did feel exposed. Our skin glowed with a light translucence. It seemed like everyone was calm, not overjoyed, but content.

I scanned the crowd in hopes of spotting someone I recognized. We were arranged neatly, each standing about 1 foot apart from one another. Our form shaped a series of circles, shrinking to a center point and expanding out impossibly wide. I couldn’t tell how far in or out I was within the series, but I couldn’t see the center nor the outer ring. Standing besides me was a younger white woman with long black hair tied in a bun. She looked to be about 30 or 40, freckles dotting her skin. I realized it was highly likely she wasn’t even from the 21st century; Perhaps she was an early colonial farmer, or an ancient nordic noble. She probably had an uneventful life and died early, as most do.

My thoughts were drowned out by a great rumbling, a blaring of trumpets, and a shifting of the ground. I looked up and saw hundreds of angels flying overhead, arranging in positions similar to our own. One of them stopped above me, gazing forward towards the center of the repeating circle. I yelled up at him, attempting to cut through the noise.

“Hey! Do you know where my parents are?” I don’t know if he heard me, but he knew my question. I could feel him look at me without turning his head, and for a moment it was as if everything else was gone and we were speaking without interruption.

“Your family are not in heaven, everyone is where they should be.” It felt like he was smiling at me, not in a mean or malicious way, but like Malak had been smiling at me. Like he really believed everything was perfect now.

My heart sank only for a moment, but I was not given time to properly comprehend what was spoken to me. A blinding light flashed from the center of the circle, a form appearing perfectly visible in my vision. I looked up at it, and my focus fully shifted. I forgot what I had just learned, forgot about the millions of people alongside me, forgot I was even naked. It didn't matter, none of it mattered, nothing else mattered. I was witness to God's glory. Time stood still and I felt perfect ecstasy. I loved it. I was happy, and I would be this happy forever.